In 1882 the Madras civil servant Robert Sewell, Collector and Judge in Chingleput, Malabar and Tirunelveli, came to the little village of Mankulam, just north of Madurai. This was well outside his area but Sewell's enthusiasm for antiquarian pursuits had led to his being given the additional role of recorder of sites of archaeological and historical importance in the Madras Presidency. This was what had brought him to Mankulam village, which nestles in the shadow of the Kalugumalai ('vulture hill') rock, rising like a great beached whale out of the dark greenery of the plains.



The Kalugumalai rock seen from the Murugan temple and tank at its foot.